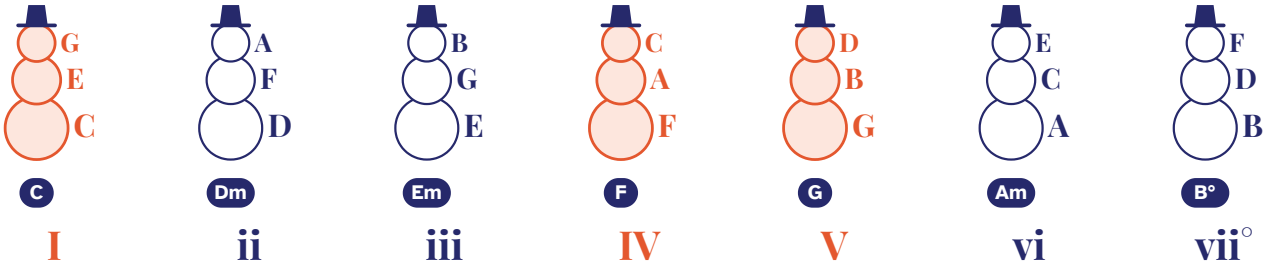
PART IV · CHORDS · 3

# Chords in a key
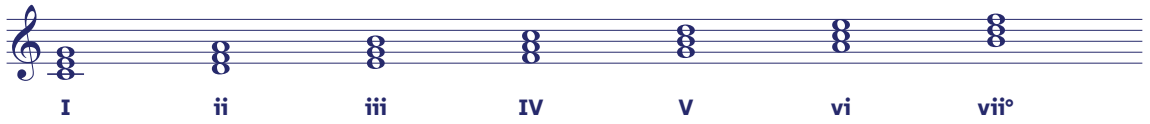
Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

**THE SECRET**

**Build a snowman on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.**




*One snowman on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work*




The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 90.

| NUMERAL | NAME | KIND | KEYS BETWEEN | IN C | IN G |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **I** | tonic | major | 3 + 2 | C | G |
| ii | supertonic | minor | 2 + 3 | Dm | Am |
| iii | mediant | minor | 2 + 3 | Em | Bm |
| **IV** | subdominant | major | 3 + 2 | F | C |
| **V** | dominant | major | 3 + 2 | G | D |
| vi | submediant | minor | 2 + 3 | Am | Em |
| vii° | leading note | diminished | 2 + 2 | B° | F♯° |

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Levels 1–2; the other chords from about Level 4.

## The three primary chords
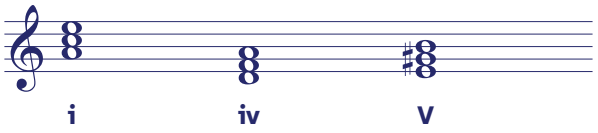
**I, IV and V** are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

**THINK OF IT** I is home. IV is a visit next door. V is the walk back, already looking at the front door: it wants to go home to I. Play C, F, G, C and hear it.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

## In a minor key

In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th**, G♯, which pulls up to the home note A. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.




A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

## Which chord holds the note?

| NOTE IN C | C | D | E | F | G | A | B |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Chord** | I or IV | V | I | IV | I or V | IV | V |

The same idea works in every key: find which of I, IV and V holds the note.

EXAMPLE 1

### Find I, IV and V in G major




1. **Count up the scale:** G A B C D. The 1st note is G, the 4th C, the 5th D.
2. **Build a triad on each,** using the key signature: the F is F♯.
3. **Check with the keys between:** all three are 3 + 2, major.

In G major: **I = G**, **IV = C**, **V = D** (D F♯ A).

GAME

### Which numeral?




All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS




### Left hand: I IV V I.

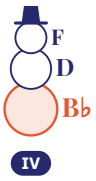
C, F, G, C, one chord per bar, four beats each. The three primary chords: nearly every nursery tune fits them.

PART IV · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

### Find I, IV and V in F major





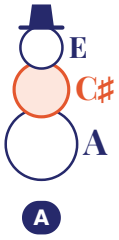


1. **Count up the scale:** F G A B♭ C. The 1st note is F, the 4th B♭, the 5th C.
2. **Build a triad on each,** with the key signature's B♭.
3. **Check:** all three are 3 + 2, major.

In F major: **I = F**, **IV = B♭**, **V = C**.

EXAMPLE 3

### Find V in D minor




1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A.
2. **Build the triad:** A C E.
3. **Raise the 7th note of the scale,** C to C♯: A C♯ E, major.

V in D minor is **A major**: the C♯ pulls up to D.

YOU KNOW THIS

### The twelve-bar blues

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| I C | I C | I C | I C |
| IV F | IV F | I C | I C |
| V G | IV F | I C | V G |

Almost every blues, and a lot of rock 'n' roll, is just **I, IV and V** in twelve bars. Learn this chart and you can play along with hundreds of songs.

**Try it.** Play the chart in C with your left hand, one chord per bar, four beats each.

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO

Four kinds of triad p. 89 · Major scales p. 69 · Cadences p. 115

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 3 · Online: Library › Chords